macroeconomic policies and steadfastly supported Elvira Nabiullina, his choice to head Russia's central bank, who was named the best Central Bank Governor in Europe in 2016 by the international financial magazine, *The Banker*. Indeed it was Russia's very market transformation and the textbook orthodox response of the Central Bank that helped stem the crisis in 2015—allowing rate hikes to combat inflation but no reintroduction of capital controls. Yet, BRICS has not been a major factor in heated economic debates between liberals and statists, partly because systemic (i.e., inside the government) liberals could help build support for Russia's integration into the global economy and the Bretton Woods order by embracing many BRICS concerns, such as a fairer distribution of voting shares and a revised formula to determine the distribution of shares in the incumbent institutions.[124]

Judging from his many speeches, interviews, and policies, Putin has learned some basic economic lessons from the notable shocks in his formative years. Although the collapse of the Soviet Union had multiple taproots, the economic and financial causes are among the most rigorously explored. The stagnating Soviet economy was hit by a perfect storm triggered by a collapse of world oil prices, which contributed to the depletion of Soviet currency reserves and the communist country's final death spiral. Weeks separated the country from bankruptcy, nonpayment of its foreign debt, and severe food shortages. Yegor Gaidar, the liberal economist appointed acting prime minister by Yeltsin to rescue Russia from impending disaster, dissected these Soviet calamities in his landmark study, "Collapse of an Empire." Among the documents that he unearthed was one from the Vneshekonombank [Foreign Economic Bank of the Soviet Union], which notified the leadership that the Soviet state had not one cent remaining in its coffers.[125] Russia went to the brink again in 1998–1999, paying a steep price for its short-term foreign currency debt and macroeconomic imbalances without the backstop of adequate reserves.

The United States and the incumbent global financial system played an important intervening role in this crisis. It reflected the White House's strategy at the time of shielding reformers from harsh economic policies that would leave them vulnerable to domestic political opponents, especially in nuclear-armed Russia, widely considered a special case in the post-communist world. In particular, the United States sought to protect Russia from the usually stringent conditionality associated with IMF